



Minaret of Jam

The world's second tallest brick minaret, famed for its intricate brickwork and inscriptions



The minaret of Jam has stood in a remote valley nestled between mountains at the edge of the ancient kingdom of Ghor in western Afghanistan for more than 800 years. It was erected by the Ghurid ruler Ghiyath al-Din, probably to commemorate an important military conquest in 1173. It is thought to have been part of Firuzkuh, the summer capital of the Ghurid Empire, which was destroyed by the Mongols under Ghengis Khan in the early 13th century.

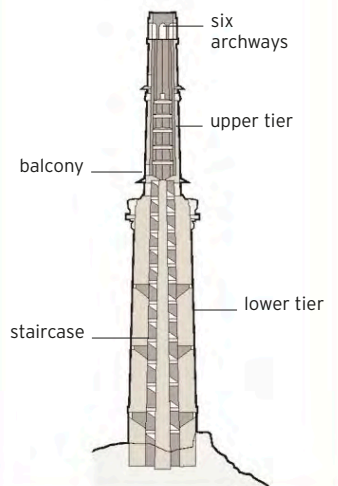
Elaborate brickwork

Standing 213 ft (65 m) high, the minaret was built entirely of red brick. It was decorated with high-relief terracotta tiles, arranged in geometric patterns of pentagons, hexagons, and diamonds, and a number of epigraphic bands in both kufic and naskh calligraphy. The inscriptions are 5–10 ft (1.5–3 m) in height and contain verses from the Qur'an and historical notes, including increasingly elaborate versions of the name and titles of Ghiyath al-Din and the name of the minaret's architect, Ali ibn Ibrahim of Nishapur.

The decoration of the minaret represents the high point of a technique typical of Afghan architecture first seen in the late 10th century. Frequent floods have damaged the base of the minaret, leaving it leaning and in danger of collapse, and it has lost more than one-fifth of its decorative brickwork.

TWO TIERS

The minaret has two levels. In the lower tier, two spiral staircases—a double-helix type not seen in Europe until the Renaissance—lead through six vaulted chambers to a balcony. In the upper tier, the stairs wind around a central void spanned by six vaults resting on four internal buttresses.



The minaret was **forgotten** after the 13th century, and **rediscovered** only in **1886**



△ TRADITIONAL CONSTRUCTION

Thick, mud-brick walls provide niches for a library beneath a ceiling constructed from split date-palm logs overlaid with palm frond matting.



△ ELABORATE INSCRIPTIONS

Five bands of decorated inscription encircle the minaret. The text is glazed in turquoise blue—the earliest known use of this feature in Ghurid architecture.

▷ ENDANGERED SITE

By 2014, a combination of floods and illegal excavations had left the minaret tilting at an angle of 3.47 degrees and in danger of collapse.

